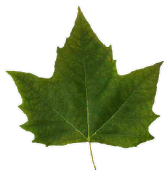


London Planetree

Platanus x acerifolia



Origin

A hybrid between the American sycamore and the Oriental planetree, first grown in Europe in the 1600s -- possibly an accident of two trees planted near each other in a garden.

Look for

Bark exfoliates in irregular puzzle-piece patches of cream, olive, and gray, exposing smooth new bark underneath -- this is the single easiest way to identify it at any time of year.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Bark: patchwork of cream, olive, and gray flaking in irregular puzzle-piece plates -- the fastest way to identify it any time of year.
- Leaf: broad, maple-like leaf with 3-5 shallow lobes, larger than a true maple leaf.
- Seed: one or two dangling ball-shaped seed clusters per stalk, often persisting into winter.
- Commonly confused with: American sycamore, its parent species (London planetree is a hybrid of sycamore and Oriental plane, usually with smaller, more deeply lobed leaves).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Large maple-like leaves unfurl; ball-shaped flower clusters appear.
Summer	Broad, deeply lobed leaves give heavy shade.
Fall	Leaves turn golden-brown and drop late.
Winter	Bare branches show off the patchwork bark and dangling seed balls.

DID YOU KNOW

- One of the most-planted street trees on Earth because it tolerates compacted soil, drought, and air pollution better than almost any other large shade tree.
- The seed balls that dangle in winter can persist on the tree for months, slowly breaking apart to release fuzzy seeds.